Guide to Growing Your Business

Planning, funding, expanding and managing the obligations that come with scaling an SME.

Source: business.gov.au — Guide to growing your business (Australian Government). Content summarised for iLoca; see business.gov.au/guide/growing for the full guide.

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1. Research and Plan for Growth

Check where you're at

Do a SWOT analysis (strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, threats) and a full financial health check before planning growth, so decisions are grounded in your actual position rather than assumptions.

Set SMART goals

Choose specific, measurable, achievable, relevant and time-bound goals, then work out the actions, people and resources needed for each. Update your business plan, marketing plan and digital strategy to reflect the new goals for growth.

2. Get Advice and Support

Experts, networks and finance

Talk to a business adviser, mentor or coach before making major changes — they can help set realistic goals, solve problems and connect you to funding opportunities. Debt finance (borrow and repay, retain full ownership) and equity finance (sell part ownership, no repayments but shared profits) are the two main ways to fund growth; government grants may also be available.

3. Review Your Business Foundations

Structure, process and premises

- Reassess your business structure if you're adding partners or need to protect personal liability
- Update policies and procedures so a growing team has consistent expectations
- Review whether your premises and equipment still fit your needs
- Compare suppliers as your volume or requirements change, and negotiate contracts that work for both sides

4. Get More Customers

Expansion channels

- Sell online through your website, social media or marketplaces (eBay, Amazon, Etsy)
- Expand your social media presence with a content calendar and consistent posting
- Consider exporting — research target markets, customs and legal requirements first
- Franchise your business model if it's proven and replicable
- Look into government or large-company tenders for long-term contracts

5. Expand What You Offer

Innovation and new products

Innovation isn't just new products — it includes new processes that save time and money, freeing up resources for growth. When developing a new product, research your idea, test a prototype, organise production, plan the launch and review after release. If importing goods, understand customs, labelling and duty requirements, and consider a licensed customs broker.

Protecting your IP

Trade marks, patents and design rights need to be registered to claim ownership; copyright and circuit layout rights are automatically protected. Identify your IP assets and monitor the market for infringement.

6. Grow Your Workforce and Capabilities

People

- Work out staffing needs and understand pay, leave and superannuation obligations before hiring
- Use contractors for short-term projects or specialist expertise, with a clear IP-ownership contract
- Consider apprentices or trainees for cost-effective, structured skill building
- Build individual development plans with staff to support long-term growth

Using AI to improve efficiency

AI can help with sales and marketing insights, research, content generation, customer support and summarising meetings or documents. Identify the specific goals or problems AI could help with, trial tools against them, involve staff in adoption (framed as support, not replacement), and understand how to use AI responsibly.

7. Manage Growth

New obligations that growth can trigger

- New licences or permits if you expand your products or services
- GST registration once annual turnover passes $75,000
- Payroll tax once total monthly wages exceed your state or territory's threshold
- Extra workplace-law responsibilities once you have more than 19 employees
- Privacy Act compliance once annual turnover exceeds $3 million

Protecting the growing business

As you scale, keep managing risk: appropriate insurance, cyber security, financial tracking, brand protection, workplace health and safety, and emergency preparedness. Maintain customer service standards and environmental management practices even as volume increases — both directly affect reputation and cost.